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# Studying with a Practical Orientation

## Universities of Applied Sciences in Germany Deutschland



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# Studying with a Practical Orientation

Universities of Applied Sciences in Germany

3rd edition



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# What are universities of applied sciences?

German universities of applied sciences, or “UAS” for short, are known for their strong practical orientation in research and teaching. They are an excellent choice for those who are interested in enrolling in a degree programme that optimally prepares them for a specific occupation.

### PARTNERS WITH COMMERCE AND INDUSTRY

All UAS work closely together with commercial and industrial partners – normally businesses located around the region. This close collaboration with the business sector drives application-oriented research and encourages the development of practical solutions.

### INSTRUCTORS WITH PRACTICAL EXPERIENCE

The professors who teach at UAS have typically worked at companies for several years themselves. Students benefit from their practical knowledge and their contacts to the business sector.

### HIGH QUALITY OF INSTRUCTION

Universities of applied sciences guarantee a high quality of instruction and offer excellent learning and research conditions. Students also receive intensive academic supervision. Classroom instruction usually takes place in small groups, allowing professors to cater to the students’ individual strengths and interests.

### OPTIMAL CHANCES FOR STARTING A CAREER

The curricular content taught at UAS is strongly aligned with the demands of the labour market for trained professionals.
That is why students are optimally prepared to start their career right after graduation.



**Prof Dr Jörg Bagdahn**
President of the Anhalt University of Applied Sciences and spokesperson for the UAS member group at the German Rectors' Conference (HRK)

**Professor Bagdahn, what makes studying at a university of applied sciences so special?**

Like the name says, universities of applied sciences specialise in application-based research. They offer degree programmes with a strong practical orientation and are directly related to the student's future occupational field. The programmes are closely coordinated with corporate and industrial partners. The focus on practical orientation is central to this form of higher education institution – and that's what makes it so attractive.

**Is there a difference between the degrees offered at a UAS and a traditional university?**

No, all German higher education qualifications are equivalent – irrespective of whether you've earned them at a UAS or a traditional university.

**Who would you recommend studying at a UAS?**

For those who wish to utilise and practically apply the knowledge they've gained in their studies, studying at a UAS is the right path. It's also ideal for those who have already gained professional training and would like to underpin their practical skills with a theoretical foundation.

# The UAS success story

Compared to traditional German universities, universities of applied sciences are relatively new. Their success story began in the 1970s when the first universities of their kind – so-called technical colleges – were established.

In just a few decades, UAS became an integral part of the German higher education and research sector.

While comprehensive universities focus on basic research, UAS specialise in application-based research activities. This practice-oriented character is not only attractive to students but also appeals to employers very much.

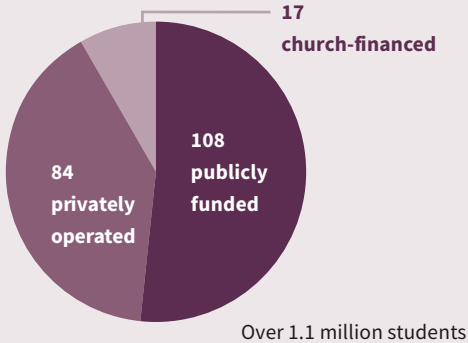
Over 1.1 million students are currently enrolled at UAS – more than 38 % of all students in Germany. And their number is growing!

This type of higher education institution has become increasingly popular among international students as well. Around 170,000 international students are currently enrolled at UAS.

Different names, one concept. Some UAS are called *Hochschulen für angewandte Wissenschaften (HAW)* and others *Fachhochschulen (FH)*, but both types are basically universities of applied sciences.

## UAS BASED ON TRUSTEESHIP (UPDATED 2025)

**209** UAS in Germany




Over 1.1 million students

## TYPES OF HIGHER EDUCATION INSTITUTIONS

| | |
|---|---|
| UAS | **209** |
| Comprehensive universities | **109** |
| Art academies | **52** |
| Colleges of public administration | **30** |
| Other university types | **22** |
| Universities in Germany in total | **422** |

## UNIVERSITY AND UAS IN COMPARISON

| University | UAS |
|---|---|
| Basic research | Applied research |
| Collaboration with other research institutes | Collaboration with companies |
| Large universities, many students | Smaller universities, intensive supervision |
| Freedom to choose electives based on one's preferences | Degree programmes follow a prescribed structure |

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# What subjects can I study at a UAS?

Universities of applied sciences offer a wide range of study opportunities. Over 7,700 degree programmes are offered at more than 200 UAS in Germany.

### DIVERSE RANGE OF SUBJECTS

Basically every subject of study is represented – from agricultural management, business administration, design, electrical engineering and computer science to medical technology and business law.

Many UAS offer a broad range of subjects. Technical, engineering and business degree programmes are especially common at UAS.

### EXCEPTIONS: MEDICINE, PHARMACY, LAW AND TEACHING

There are a few subjects which can only be studied at comprehensive universities. These are tied to a specific career goal and conclude with a state examination (*Staatsexamen*): medicine, pharmacy and law. The other exception is teaching degree programmes (*Lehramt*) that conclude with a state examination and qualify students to teach at public schools.





**Prof Dr Edeltraud Vomberg**
President of the Düsseldorf University of Applied Sciences

**Professor Vomberg, what sets UAS degree programmes apart from those at other universities?**

The programmes are characterised by a strong practical orientation. The course content is often supplemented by instructors with professional experience in business, administration or the cultural sector and closely align with real-world requirements. At the same time, many degree programmes offer flexible options that allow students to gain specialisation in individual areas. Students are trained in an environment where theory and application are deliberately intertwined and where they are specifically prepared to start their career.

**What else distinguishes these degree programmes?**

A central feature is how they combine application-oriented learning with modern didactic approaches. This includes project-based work, interdisciplinary formats and learning environments like makerspaces and real-world labs, where students come up with their own solutions to concrete problems. Students from different disciplines often work together and tackle practice-relevant challenges, which in turn enhances their specialist knowledge, methodological competence and social skills.

It's also worth mentioning the interdisciplinary and future-oriented degree programmes, for example, in the field of digital transformation. Some UAS are now qualifying so-called "digital generalists" who are trained to identify, understand and use technological advances in various fields of application.

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# How are the degree programmes structured?

All UAS offer bachelor's and master's degree programmes which conclude with the conferral of internationally recognised higher education certificates. Compared with comprehensive universities, UAS degree programmes are more rigorously structured and often include integrated practical semesters, project phases and work placements.

### BACHELOR'S PROGRAMMES

Bachelor's programmes usually take six to eight semesters to complete, of which one is often a practical semester. Bachelor's programmes almost always contain integrated practical phases. They enable students to gain work experience and cultivate contacts with potential employers during their studies. They also encourage professional orientation, as students can familiarise themselves with a potential occupational field intensively for an entire semester.

### MASTER'S PROGRAMMES

Master's programmes generally last four semesters and have a clear, practice-oriented focus. Many students write their master's thesis at a company. This entails researching a topic that is important to the respective firm and finding concrete solutions which can be practically applied. In many cases, students are offered a job by these same companies after graduation.



After a master's degree, you can also pursue a doctorate at a UAS. Doctoral degrees are now offered at 20 UAS in Germany. Alternatively, you can transfer to a comprehensive university and pursue a doctorate there as well.



**Raquel de Quadros Weber**
pursuing a master's degree (MSc) in *Design Leadership* at
the Ingolstadt University of Applied Science

## I'M MOTIVATED BY THE COMBINATION OF DESIGN, BUSINESS AND INNOVATION

Design has a very strong tradition in Germany. That's why – ever since my bachelor's programme – it's been a big wish of mine to study in Germany.

The practice-oriented approach was what especially convinced me to study at the Ingolstadt University of Applied Sciences. My programme goes well beyond classical design by combining business and strategic content with concrete project work.

My university also fosters close contacts with commercial stakeholders. Not only the university itself, but also trade fairs, company visits and other events provide me with valuable insights into the practical aspects of the job and the labour market.

Here at the university, I've learned to work in interdisciplinary and multicultural teams, jointly develop ideas and carry out projects. What I especially like is the close contact I have with my professors and the international setting with students from all around the world.

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# How do I find a suitable UAS?

With over 200 UAS and more than 7,700 degree programmes to choose from, deciding where to study is not always easy.

### ALL OPTIONS AT A GLANCE

For a good overview of where universities are located and what programmes they offer, the Higher Education Compass of the German Rectors' Conference (HRK) is a good place to start: **www.daad.de/study-programmes**.

### PROGRAMMES FOR INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS

Many UAS offer international degree programmes tailored to the specific needs of international students. You can find a listing of these programmes and study preparation courses at **www.daad.de/international-programmes**.

### UNIVERSITY RANKINGS

The quality of research and teaching is relatively high at all German universities. Consequently, university rankings in Germany do not play such an influential role as they do in other countries.

A popular ranking list is the CHE University Ranking. It assesses the evaluations of some 120,000 students and 3,000 professors. You can find information on around 40 subjects of study at some 370 universities at **www.daad.de/che-ranking**.



**Gernot Welschhoff**
advised international students at the Berlin University of Applied Sciences (HTW) for many years. He currently serves as chairman of the HTW Staff Council.

**Mr Welschhoff, how would you go about looking for a suitable UAS?**

I'd begin by consulting **www.study-guide.com** for an overview of what universities offer my subject of study. Then I'd compare degree programmes: How are the programmes structured? What topics do they concretely focus on? And what prerequisites do I have to meet?

After that, I'd take a closer look at my top picks. How internationally oriented is the UAS? Are there special advisory services for international students? And then, of course, my personal preferences also play a role. What do I find more appealing – a larger or smaller university? Where would I like to live?

**What should international students consider when planning their study visit?**

Start collecting information as early as possible and reach out to the representatives at the UAS for advice. Another thing – always go directly to the source so that you have the most current information. For example, for visa matters, visit the website of the German embassy.

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# What are the admission requirements?

Requirements for admission can vary depending on your choice of degree programme and university. For some programmes, applicants must first complete a work placement to be eligible for admission (pre-study internship).

As prerequisites can vary, it is a good idea to inquire at the UAS of your choice about its specific admission criteria as soon as possible.

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The International Office at your university is the first place of contact for questions about degree programmes, study requirements, planning a course of study and residing in Germany.

### HIGHER EDUCATION ENTRANCE QUALIFICATION

As a rule, all prospective students must hold a higher education entrance qualification to study in Germany. This could be, for example, a school-leaving certificate that qualifies you for admission to a German university. Various international school-leaving certificates are considered equivalent to the German higher education entrance qualification, such as the German *Abitur* or *Fachabitur*.

At **www.daad.de/admission-database** or **www.study-guide.com**, international students can determine whether their school-leaving certificate is recognised as a higher education entrance qualification in Germany.

Sometimes it is possible to study at a UAS without a higher education qualification. In such cases, one must hold a recognised vocational qualification and/or have several years of work experience.

## ASSESSMENT TEST AT A PREPARATORY COLLEGE

If your school-leaving certificate is not sufficient for admission, you can earn your higher education entrance qualification here in Germany if you fulfil certain prerequisites.

This takes place at a so-called *Studienkolleg*, or preparatory college, where prospective students can prepare for university study. Most courses take two semesters to complete and conclude with an examination. For more information about *Studienkollegs*, visit **www.daad.de/prep-courses**.

## STARTING AFTER YOUR BACHELOR'S DEGREE

Often it is easier for international students to gain admission to a German UAS if they have already completed a bachelor's programme in another country.

Depending on their country of origin, international students may require an entry visa before travelling to Germany. For more information, contact the German embassy or consulate in your country, or visit **www.auswaertiges-amt.de/en/visa-service**.

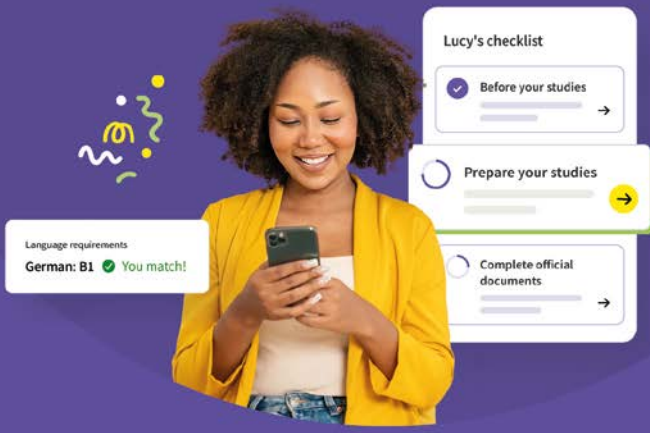




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# How good does my German have to be?

Like any other country, the same holds for Germany – your German skills will go a long way to help you feel comfortable in your new environment, overcome everyday challenges and make friends and acquaintances. The question of how good your German has to be in order to study, and which language exam or test score is required for admission, is up to the universities to decide. And even these requirements can vary depending on your choice of degree programme. More information is available at the International Office at the respective UAS.

### STUDYING IN ENGLISH

UAS offer more and more degree programmes in English every year. In fact, English is the primary language of instruction in nearly 900 degree programmes. Those who apply to such a programme must present proof of good English skills.

### STUDYING IN GERMAN

Likewise, one must present proof of sufficient German language ability to get accepted to a German-language degree programme. This is done with an official test score from a recognised language exam. As a rule, students who earn an *Abitur* at a German school abroad are not required to take a German language test.

### GERMAN LANGUAGE TESTS

There are several fee-based tests, with which you can prove your German language proficiency. These include:

- The **Test of German as a Foreign Language (TestDaF)**, which one can take at over 500 testing centres in 100 countries worldwide, and
- the **German Language Test for Admission of Foreign Study Applicants (DSH)**, which is offered at universities in Germany.

UAS usually recognise other language tests as well, such as the Goethe-Zertifikat C2 and the telc Deutsch C1 Hochschule exam.



**Yasmine Ben Bennani**
pursuing a bachelor's degree in *biotechnology* at the
Aachen University of Applied Sciences

## LIFE IN GERMANY IS DIVERSE AND INTERNATIONAL

German language skills are very important for my studies since all my courses are taught in German. That's why it was imperative to learn the language well and to attain a certain level of fluency. Good German skills are not only important for lectures, but also for exams, internships and everyday life.

Before I came to Germany, I took an A1-level German course in my home country of Tunisia. In Aachen, I attended an intensive language course for about ten months. Today I can speak German fluently and have no problems expressing myself in daily life, at university or in a professional context.

What I find very enriching in Germany is that you meet people from countries and cultures all around the world. I also appreciate how well organised certain aspects of life are and how safe you feel. I especially like the student atmosphere in Aachen and that you can quickly make contacts. It's even easier if you can speak German.

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# How much does it cost to study in Germany?

There are various expenses tied to studying in Germany. In addition to regular living expenses, you will have to pay for health insurance and your semester fees. Depending on your university and degree programme, you may also be required to pay tuition fees.

All students at German higher education institutions pay semester fees. These are not the same as tuition fees. Semester fees finance the work of the *Studierendenwerk* (Student Support Services) and the student council.

## LIVING EXPENSES

The cost of living in Germany is slightly higher than the European average.

Students usually need between 900 and 1,200 euros per month to cover their living expenses. The amount you actually need will largely depend on your personal lifestyle. Taking a room in a student hall of residence, for example, is cheaper than renting a flat. The location of the university also plays a role. Large cities are usually more expensive than smaller ones.

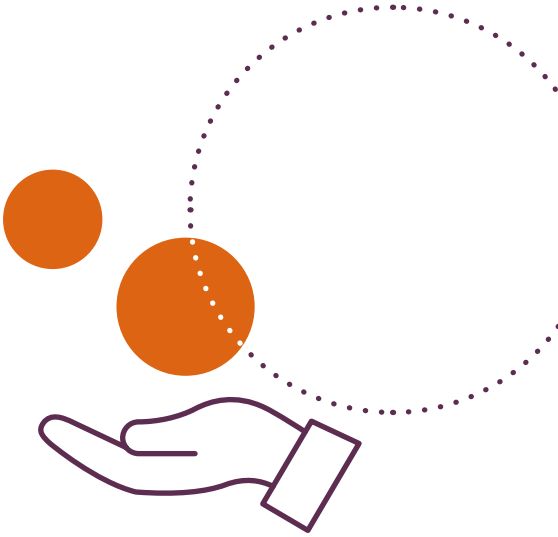
International students are required to present proof of financial resources to confirm that they can finance their studies by themselves. Currently students must show that they have 992 euros per month (11,904 euros per year) at their disposal.

## TUITION FEES

A little over half of German UAS are publicly funded. As a rule, bachelor's and most master's programmes at these state universities are tuition-free. For certain post-graduate master's programmes, students may be required to pay tuition fees, but compared with other countries, the tuition is relatively low.

The exception: In the state of Baden-Württemberg, international students from non-EU countries are required to pay 1,500 euros in tuition per semester (= half year) for their first degree programme.

The tuition costs at private universities can be even higher – between 200 and 1,700 euros per month. Therefore, before applying to a private university, we recommend checking the current tuition rates on their website as these can change each year.





**Mas'udah**
enrolled in an interdisciplinary doctoral programme in the field of process engineering at the Offenburg University of Applied Sciences

**Mas'udah, what are you working on as a doctoral candidate at the UAS in Offenburg?**

I'm working on methods where AI can generate sustainable innovations in engineering with a particular focus on the early phases of process development.

**Why did you decide to study at the Offenburg University of Applied Science?**

There's a broad range of research activities – also international – in the field of sustainable process engineering. The UAS in Offenburg offers me the opportunity to work on relevant, future-oriented research topics.

The intensive supervision was another important factor for me. I really value the close collaboration with the professors.

**Offenburg is a relatively small university town. How do you like living here?**

It's great! Offenburg is a quiet, relaxed city with a high quality of life. I like being so close to nature! Everything here is in short walking distance. And there are very few distractions, so I can concentrate entirely on my research. Whenever I'm in the mood to visit a big city, I can be in Freiburg and Strasbourg in no time.



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# How can I finance my studies?

There are numerous institutions and foundations that offer a wide variety of scholarships and funding opportunities to international students. Funding is available for short- and long-term study visits, as well as language courses and work placements.

### SCHOLARSHIPS

You can find numerous funding possibilities for international students in the DAAD Scholarship Database at **www.funding-guide.de**.

> The DAAD operates a global network of regional offices and information centres which can assist you with finding and applying for a suitable scholarship.

Universities offer scholarships as well. For instance, over 10,500 students at UAS in Germany receive financial aid through the Deutschlandstipendium. Therefore, it pays to inquire about such scholarships at the university of your choice.

### PART-TIME JOBS

A part-time job can help you finance your studies in Germany. However, it is almost impossible to cover your entire living expenses with a part-time job while studying at the same time.

Although it's possible to work as a research assistant at a university, there are many other places that are always looking for part-time help – cafés, restaurants, delivery services, private tutoring etc.

Depending on their country of origin, special rules apply regarding how many days per year international students are allowed to work without special permission from the Federal Employment Agency.



**Mariana Zaldaña**
pursuing her bachelor's degree in *architecture* at
the Anhalt University of Applied Sciences

**Ms Zaldaña, why did you decide to study at the UAS Anhalt?**

I was fascinated by its proximity to the Bauhaus in Dessau. The Bauhaus has had a major impact on architectural history, and I found it inspiring to study in a setting closely tied to this tradition.

**What do you like about life in Germany?**

I like the quality of life, how safe it is and the possibility of meeting people from different cultures.

**How are you financing your studies?**

It's a combination of support from my family, living off my savings and working part-time. I work at the International Office at my university. I help them issue documents, update general information and maintain the website, especially the area of Erasmus progress reports.

**What advice do you have for saving money in Germany?**

I recommend planning a monthly budget so that you have a good overview of your expenses. Loyalty apps at supermarkets and pharmacies are really helpful because they regularly offer rebates and coupons.

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# What is a dual study programme?

A dual study programme combines academic study at a UAS with vocational training at a company. Currently there are over 1,700 dual study opportunities at German universities of applied sciences.

### STUDY AND VOCATIONAL TRAINING

In a dual study programme, students enter a contractual relationship with a company. They are employed there and are paid for their work. Depending on the company, you can earn between 400 and 1,800 euros per month. Bear in mind, however, that it's practically impossible to work part-time while enrolled in a dual study programme.

Many companies that offer on-the-job training in dual study programmes hire their trainees after graduation. In other words, a dual study programme can help you gain a quick foothold in the German labour market.

### MOTIVATION AND PERSEVERANCE

Studying and completing vocational training at the same time can be quite a challenge! To get the most out of a dual study programme, candidates must be highly motivated, self-disciplined and persevering – and good German skills are always a plus.

Depending on their country of origin, international students often require a work visa to enrol in a dual study programme.

In the database AusbildungPlus and the Higher Education Compass, you can find a list of all dual degree programmes and further information: **www.bibb.de/ausbildungplus** and **www.daad.de/study-programmes**.



**Lisa Schneider**
Head of international relations at the Baden-Württemberg Cooperative State University (DHBW), where she also advises international students

**Ms Schneider, what makes dual study appealing to international students?**

Dual study programmes are offered at UAS in relatively small groups. Courses rarely have more than 30 students, which guarantees intensive supervision and helps create a pleasant, personal learning environment. Students also receive intensive supervision during their practical phase at the company. This makes it easy to establish private and professional contacts – and to get acclimated in Germany.

What students find especially attractive is the financial independence that dual study programmes offer. During the entire programme, students are employed at the company and receive a monthly salary.

**How are their career prospects?**

Dual study offers the best career opportunities and easy entry into the labour market! More than 85% of graduates from the Baden-Württemberg Cooperative State University are hired by the companies they trained at and have usually signed an employment contract even before they've completed their studies!

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# What special programmes are offered to international students?

The International Offices at UAS provide assistance, advice and a wide range of support services to students from around the world – with planning their study visit and offering help after arriving in Germany.

### ORIENTATION COURSES

Many UAS offer orientation courses or other information events for international students at the beginning of their studies. They help new students get off to a good start academically and in everyday life in Germany.

Even during one's studies, cultural events, excursions and similar programmes are organised on a regular basis.

### BUDDY PROGRAMMES

Buddy programmes are offered at many universities. These programmes pair up international students with experienced students who support them during their first days in Germany. For example, they accompany them to registration offices, provide orientation on campus and answer any questions they have.

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There are many ways to make friends at university and in university towns. These include clubs and university groups, such as university sport courses, associations and choirs. In addition to student parties, there are digital meet-ups on social media, apps like Bumble Friends and a wide variety of student groups on campus.



**Tianyi Guo**
studied chemistry and applied *polymer sciences* at the Aachen University of Applied Sciences and went on to earn his doctorate in chemistry and biotechnology. Today he works as a postdoc at the *Forschungszentrum Jülich*.

## FULL SUPPORT WHATEVER THE PROBLEM

**Mr Guo, do you feel well taken care of at your university?**

Yes, absolutely! The International Office provided extensive support from the very beginning. From my experience as an international student at the UAS Aachen, you'll always find someone who can help you handle the challenges of academic and daily life.

What I also found incredibly useful were the German courses offered in the first two semesters. That's where I learned everything I needed to know language-wise for my courses, presentations and even work placements.

**You spent two years during your studies supporting other international students as a *buddy* yourself.**

That's right. When I first came to Germany, I too received support from a buddy. That helped me so much get accustomed to the campus and everyday life!

That's why I felt it was important to share my own experiences with others as a buddy. I wanted to do my part to make the new students feel comfortable. And besides, it was a lot of fun!

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# What are my career prospects after graduation?

An important goal of UAS is to prepare students for the demands of the labour market as best as possible by providing them with a practically oriented, academic training.

### GOOD PROSPECTS WORLDWIDE

Universities of applied sciences not only prepare graduates for the German labour force but also more generally for the global market. Consequently, many UAS offer courses with an international orientation and cooperate closely with partners around the world.

German UAS enjoy an excellent reputation worldwide. As a result, UAS graduates have very good chances of securing jobs on the international labour market.

### BUSINESS CONTACTS

Students at UAS already begin cultivating contacts with companies during their studies through practical phases and work placements. These same companies often become the graduates' first employers.

### WORKING IN GERMANY

Those who want to stay in Germany after graduation have great career prospects. The reason being that numerous business sectors in Germany are desperately seeking well-trained professionals.

Students from non-EU countries can extend their residence permit after completing their studies. They then have up to 18 months to find a job that corresponds to their subject of study.

Those who find a suitable position are granted a temporary residence permit. After two years, one can apply for a permanent residence permit, with which one can live and work in Germany indefinitely.



**Peter Githinji Githiri**
completed a postgraduate programme in "Food Chains in the Agricultural Sector" at the Weihenstephan-Triesdorf University of Applied Sciences. Today he works at an NGO with headquarters in Kenya.

**Mr Githinji Githiri, why did you decide to study at the UAS Weihenstephan-Triesdorf?**

The degree programmes at this university focus on sustainable consumption and the protection of natural resources which exactly aligns with my interest.

**What do you do now professionally?**

I work on projects that aim to enhance value chains using solutions from the field of renewable energies. The NGO I work for manages projects across Africa, and my role is to help farmers increase their productivity.

**How did your degree from Germany help you?**

I acquired a great deal of expertise and practical skills in Germany. Now I'm constantly applying these in my profession to develop and implement effective, market-oriented solutions.

After my studies, I also received a grant from the Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit (GIZ). It allowed me to carry out a project of my own that provided solar-powered irrigation to smallholders. That definitely wouldn't have been possible without having studied in Triesdorf.

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# Where can I find more information?

www.daad.de/en/: The DAAD website contains the most important information on studying in Germany. Available in German and English, the website provides information on universities, degree programmes and admission requirements, along with helpful advice on studying and everyday life in Germany.

**YOU CAN FIND FURTHER INFORMATION:**

- at the Information Centres (ICs), Information Points (IPs) and Regional Offices of the DAAD (for addresses, visit: **www.daad.de/en/the-daad/contact/addresses-telephone-numbers/**)
- from the Lektors and instructors assigned to international universities by the DAAD
- at the Goethe-Institute
- at German diplomatic missions abroad, i.e. German embassies and consulates

**INTERNATIONAL OFFICES**

If you've already decided on a degree programme and UAS, you should quickly contact the International Office at the university of your choice. You can do this, for example, by using Study Guide Germany (**www.study-guide.com/en**) or visiting the website of the respective university. Then you can plan your next steps together with the staff at the International Office.

Please bear in mind, that the application process for a study place can take some time depending on the admission requirements and your country of origin.

**STUDYING IN GERMANY**

www.daad.de/en/study-and-research-in-germany/

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# Universities of applied sciences (UAS) in Germany



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**Published by**
Deutscher Akademischer Austauschdienst e. V.
Kennedyallee 50, D-53175 Bonn

The DAAD is an association of German universities and their student bodies. It is institutionally funded by the German Federal Foreign Office.

Section K23 – Information on Studying in Germany

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**Editor**
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**Layout**
DITHO Design GmbH, Cologne

**Translation**
Robert Brambeer, Pforzheim

**Printed by**
Brandt Druck & Verlag GmbH,
Rathausgasse 13, 53111 Bonn

www.blauer-engel.de/uz195
• ressourcenschonend und umweltfreundlich hergestellt
• emissionsarm gedruckt
• aus 100 % Altpapier
RI1

3rd edition, September 2026 – 10,000 copies
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Supported by:

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